

No. No. Not another one. If it's a bill, a complaint, or a note from somebody with "thoughts about the theatre," burn it before I read it.

It's all three, Hakim. The same envelope.

And who opened this room? It looks like a waiting room for actors nobody called back.

Then for once we are perfectly cast.

Save your wit, Paul — leave the words to the author. A little light, please — if the house has any left to spare us this evening.

Half light. It's what's left.

Half light, half a company, half a budget. We're ready for Pirandello. God help us.

Come along! Second act of "Mixing It Up" — and play it, this once, as if you wanted the public back for the third.

The public came back for the third act once.

For you?

It was raining.

Then let's pray for rain.

"Leo Gala's house. A curious room serving as dining-room and study."

Elena — fix up the old red room.

The red room is blue now. We painted over it in March.

Then make it red.

With what, sir? Hope? Same flats as the blue room. I'll turn them round.

"When the curtain rises, Leo Gala, in cook's cap and apron, is busy beating an egg in a cup..."

Yes — real eggs, if the budget runs to it. Mime them.

Excuse me. Must I absolutely wear a cook's cap?

It says so there.

But it's *ridiculous*. I have a reputation in this canton — fifteen years of it, and not one inch built on a cook's cap.

Fifteen years. And the cap is what finally finishes you.

Ridiculous? Of course it's ridiculous — that is the whole job. We are paid to make ridiculous things look inevitable. So put on the cap, Paul. Beat the egg. Become the shell.

The shell?

Empty, fragile, and cracked before the public arrives. Try not to overplay it. And is it my fault France keeps its good comedies for Paris and sends us Pirandello — whom nobody understands, least of all the people paid to perform him?

I'd sooner resign.

He resigns every Tuesday.

Let the record show I wear it under protest.

The record is noted. The record is always noted. Chair, book — and somebody pretend we are a theatre.

Pardon, sir — may I get into my box? There's a draught off that door they've still not mended, and I'd rather not be hoarse for my first proper season.

Yes, yes, Arsenii — in, in. And mind that draught. We can't afford your throat either.

Do we ever rehearse anything real?

Real? God forbid. Real things ruin a rehearsal.

Excuse me, sir — *désolé* to interrupt; I know you don't like the morning's work disturbed...

Eh? What is it?

These people are asking for you, sir. I did tell them you were busy. They insisted.

I am rehearsing, and you know perfectly well no one's allowed to come in during rehearsals! Who are you, please? What do you want?

Actually... we have come here in search of an author...

An author? What author?

Any author, sir.

But there's no author here. We are not rehearsing a new piece.

So much the better, sir, so much the better. You can put us on tonight — we'll draw better than whatever you were rehearsing.

Oh — do you hear that?

We were drawing perfectly well. ...Adequately.

Yes, but if the author isn't here... unless you would be willing...

You are trying to be funny. We have neither the time nor the budget for funny.

No, for Heaven's sake, what are you saying? We bring you a drama, sir.

We may be your fortune, sir — if you have the nerve for us.

Will you oblige me by going away? *Allez*, please. We haven't time to waste with mad people. We have our own.

You call us mad because we come without a book. But isn't that your work — to make invented things seem true? We are true already. We only lack the stage.

But I beg you to believe, my dear sir, that the actor's profession is a noble one. If today's playwrights give us stupid comedies to play and puppets instead of real people, remember — we are proud to have given life to immortal works on these very boards.

Exactly, perfectly. To living beings more alive than those who breathe and wear clothes — beings less real, perhaps, but truer. Truer because they cannot lie about themselves the way we can. I agree with you entirely.

Truer. He has been using that word for years. Ask my mother how true it sounded.

What do you mean? A moment ago you were saying the opposite.

No, sir. I mean only this: you know better than anyone that imagination gives bodies to things that would otherwise remain invisible.

Very well — but where does all this take us?

Nowhere — only to show you we were born this way. Characters. Alive. And left without a stage.

So you and these other friends of yours have been born characters?

Exactly, and alive as you see! I am sorry you laugh, because we carry in us a drama, as you can guess from this woman here veiled in black.

Oh, enough! Out, please! Clear out of here! Paul — for Heaven's sake, turn them out!

No, no, look here, we...

We come here to work, you know.

One cannot allow oneself to be made a fool of.

Your disbelief amazes me, gentlemen. Aren't you used to seeing the characters created by an author spring to life in yourselves and face each other? Just because there is no "book" which contains us, you refuse to believe...

Believe me, we are really six most interesting characters, sir — left stranded halfway.

Sancho Panza lives. Madame Bovary lives. Their authors died, but they remain. We were born too — but left without a world to hold us.

He has said all this to himself before. Many times.

That is quite all right. But what do you want here, all of you?

We want to live.

For Eternity?

No, sir, only for a moment... in you.

They want to live, in *us*... as if there were room.

Look here! look here! The comedy has to be made. But if you and your actors are willing, we can soon arrange it among ourselves.

But what do you want to arrange? We don't arrange things here. Here we play dramas, comedies, and — once a year, against my better judgment — a musical revue. Not whatever this is.

Exactly! That is just why we have come to you.

And where is the "book"?

It is in us! The drama is in us, and we are the drama. Our inner passion drives us on to this.

His passion. Always the word *passion*. My passion, sir. Ah, if you only knew — my passion for *him*.

Behave yourself! And please don't laugh in that fashion.

With your permission, gentlemen, I, who am a two months' orphan, will show you how well I can dance and sing. *Don't worry — it isn't a hymn*.

Bravo! Well done! Encore!

Silence! This isn't a café concert, you know! Is she mad?

She can hold a stage. I'll say that.

Mad? No, she's worse than mad.

Worse? Listen! Stage this drama now, sir! At a certain moment, when we lose this little darling, and this fool here does the stupidest thing — you will see me run away. But the moment hasn't come yet. After what has taken place between him and me, I can't stay here, watching her anguish over that fool. Look at him — frigid, indifferent, because he is the *legitimate* son. He despises us all because we are bastards. And he won't even recognise her as his mother. *Wretch*.

In the name of these two little children, I beg you... Oh God!

Quick, a chair, a chair for this poor widow!

Is it true? Has she really fainted?

Quick, a chair! Here!

Look at her! Look at her!

No, no; stop it please!

Let them see you!

I beg you, sir. Stop him. I cannot bear what he wants to do.

I don't understand at all. Is this lady your wife?

Yes, gentlemen: my wife!

But how can she be a widow if you are alive?

Don't laugh! Don't laugh like that, for Heaven's sake. Her drama lies just here in this: she has had a lover, a man who should be here.

No! No!

Fortunately for her, sir, he is dead. Two months ago, as I said. We are in mourning, as you see. Most respectable.

He isn't here — but not because he is dead. He isn't here because her drama is not a drama of love at all. She felt nothing for either of us — perhaps a little gratitude, not for me, for the other. She isn't a woman, she is a mother. And her drama, sir, lies all in these four children she has had by two men.

I had them? Have you got the courage to say that I wanted them? It was him. He gave me to that other man. He made me go.

It isn't true.

Not true? And what can you know about it?

It isn't true. Don't believe it. Do you know why she says so? For that fellow there. She tortures herself, destroys herself on account of the neglect of that son there; and she wants him to believe that if she abandoned him when he was only two years old, it was because this man forced her to it.

He forced me to it. And I call God to witness it. Ask him if it isn't true. *Let him speak.* You are not in a position to know anything about it.

I know you lived in peace and happiness with my father while he lived. Can you deny it?

No, I don't deny it...

He was always full of affection and kindness for you. It's true, isn't it? Tell them! Why don't you speak, you little fool?

Leave him alone. Why do you want to make me appear ungrateful, daughter? I don't want to offend your father. I have told him: I did not leave my house and my son through any fault of mine. Not from any wilful passion.

It's true. It was my doing.

What a spectacle. What an absolute...

We are the audience this time.

For once.

Let's hear them out. Listen!

Oh yes, you're going to hear a fine bit now. He will talk to you of the Demon of Experiment.

You are a cynical imbecile. He mocks me for the phrase I've found to excuse myself with.

Yes. Phrases. Phrases.

Phrases! And isn't everyone consoled by a word — some simple word that means nothing, and yet calms us?

Words cost nothing. He was prepared to pay.

Must you—

Yes, there was money. A nice little bit. The hundred francs he was about to lay down for me, gentlemen — and I two months an orphan.

This is vile.

Vile? There they were in a pale blue envelope on a little mahogany table in the back of Madame Pace's shop. You know Madame Pace, sir — one of those *ladies* who take in poor girls of good family on the pretext of selling *robes et manteaux*. The pretext is always *robes*. The arrangement is always something else.

And he thinks he bought the right to tyrannize over us with that hundred francs. Which — note this, gentlemen — he never got the chance to pay.

It was a near thing, though, you know!

Shame, my daughter. Not in front of her.

Shame? Oh, the shame is mine — and the *revenge*. I am dying to live that scene. The room — I see it. Here is the window with the mantles in display, there the divan, a screen, and in front of the window the little mahogany table with the blue envelope and its hundred francs. I can almost take hold of it. But you, gentlemen, might look elsewhere for this part of it. I do not blush, however. *He* does.

I don't understand this at all.

Of course. — Sir. Before you decide what she has just put on me, you must let me explain.

Ah yes, explain it in your own way.

Words are the whole trouble. Each of us carries a whole world inside him, sir; and when I speak, I put my world into the words — and she, listening, fills them with hers. We think we understand each other.

We never do. I say one thing, she hears another — and the explanation becomes another crime.

But you drove me away.

Do you hear her? I drove her away! She truly believes it.

You know how to talk, and I don't. But believe me, sir — after he had married me... who knows why?... I was a poor woman. Nothing.

— it was for your humility that I married you. You see — she denies it. She has never been able to hear me. She has a heart for the children. When I speak — nothing.

Yes, but ask him how his intelligence has helped us.

If we could see all the evil that can come from good, what would we do?

Hakim — *mais sérieusement* — are we going to rehearse today, or not?

Of course, of course — but let's hear them out. You must please explain yourself quite clearly.

Very well then: listen! I had in my service a poor clerk, a secretary, full of devotion, who became friends with her. Kindred souls — without the slightest suspicion of evil between them.

So he thought of it — for them!

That's not true. I meant to do good to them — and to myself, I confess. It reached the point where I couldn't say a word to either of them without their exchanging a silent look — how to keep me calm, how to keep me quiet. And that alone kept me in a constant rage. So I sent him away — and then had to watch this poor woman wandering the house like an animal without a master — an animal one has taken in out of pity.

Ah yes...

It's true about the son anyway, isn't it?

He took my son away from me first of all.

But not from cruelty. I sent him to a wet nurse in the country, a peasant, so that he should grow up healthy and strong.

As one can see.

Is it my fault if he has grown up like this? All my life I have had these damned aspirations toward a moral sanity I never quite reach.

Yes, please stop it, for Heaven's sake.

But imagine moral sanity from *him*, if you please — a regular customer of Madame Pace's shop. A very regular customer.

— These are not the lines of a play I auditioned for.

Fool! That contradiction, gentlemen, is the proof that I stand here a *live* man before you — exactly this incongruity in my nature has made me suffer. I couldn't live beside that woman any longer; not for the boredom she inspired in me — for the pity I felt for her.

He calls it pity. He was caught buying his stepdaughter in the back of a dressmaker's shop. He calls it *pity*.

And so he turned me out —.

— well provided for! Yes, I sent her to that man, gentlemen... to let her go free of me.

And to free himself.

Yes. I admit it. It was a liberation, also, for me. I did it for her sake more than for mine. Did I ever lose sight of you — until that other man carried you off to another town? I watched — from a long way off — the new family that grew up around you. She can tell you that.

Oh yes, that's true enough. When I was little, so high, you know, with plaits over my shoulders and my skirt down past my knees, I used to see him waiting outside the school for me to come out. He came, sir, to see how I was *growing up*. He used to follow me in the street. I told my mother, who guessed at once and wouldn't send me to school for some days. When I went back, there he was again, with a paper parcel: a fine straw hat, a bouquet of flowers. For me.

Infamous! infamous! After she went away, my house seemed suddenly empty. She had been my nightmare, but she filled my house. I was like a dazed fly alone in the empty rooms. Then I was driven — curiosity at first, later something tenderer — toward the family that had come into being through my will.

Should we be writing this down? Some of it sounds important.

A bit discursive this, you know!

Literature. Literature.

This is life, this is passion, sir — but I agree: it is only the part leading up. She, as you see, is no longer the schoolgirl with plaits down her back —.

— and the skirt down past the knee! As soon as my father died...

— there was absolute misery for them. They came back here, without my knowing. She can barely write her own name — but her daughter could have written a line.

And how was I to divine all this sentiment in him — after so many years apart, and all that had happened...

Was it my fault if that fellow carried you away? I could find no trace of them — and, naturally, my interest dwindled. Then they came back — and the loneliness still had its grip on me. Every man carries things in the secrecy of his own heart that he would never say aloud. One gives way to a moment's weakness, and then rises from it, and is himself again — and the moment is not the man. Most men

simply haven't the courage to admit the moment was ever there at all. That is the only difference between us.

All appear to have the courage to do them though.

Yes, but in secret. Two people drift toward a thing neither will name; the moment they are caught at it, they both look away. It is the way we tell each other: *blind yourself, because I have*.

Sometimes one of the two cannot look away any more — when she no longer feels the need of hiding her shame from herself, but dry-eyed and dispassionately sees only the shame of the man who has blinded himself without love. Oh, this philosophy that uncovers the worst in a man and then excuses him — I can't stand it, sir. When a man simplifies life down to appetite, throwing aside every finer thing — duty, modesty, shame — nothing is more revolting than the remorse that follows. Crocodile's tears, that's what it is.

Crocodile's tears. How easily she says it. Then ask yourselves, gentlemen, why she guards that one moment of mine so jealously. Because if I am more than that moment — she has to forgive me. And she would rather burn than forgive.

Let's come to the point. This is only discussion.

Very good, sir! A fact is like a sack — it won't stand up when it's empty. For it to stand up, you must put into it the reason and sentiment that caused it. I couldn't know that after his death they had come back here, in misery — and that she had gone to work as a seamstress — in the shop of a certain Madame Pace.

You will believe me, gentlemen, that it never entered my mind that the old hag offered me work because she had her eye on my daughter.

Poor Mother! Do you know what that woman did, sir? When I brought back the work my mother had finished, she would point out a dress of mine I had torn — and give it back to my mother to mend. It was I who paid, always I — while this poor creature believed she was sacrificing herself for us, sitting up at night sewing Madame Pace's dresses.

And one day you met there...

Him, him. Yes sir, an old client. There's a scene for you to play! Superb!

She, the Mother arrived just then...

Almost in time.

No — in time. *In time*. And I took them back home with me. You can imagine now her position and mine; she, as you see her, and I who cannot look her in the face.

Absurd! How can I possibly be expected — after *that* — to play the modest young miss, fit company for his damned aspirations of "a solid moral sanity"?

She wants to nail me forever to that one room, that one table, that one envelope.

You walked into that room by yourself.

Pardon — did we just witness a *confession*?

Don't look at me. I don't come into this.

What? You don't come into this?

I've got nothing to do with it. And I don't want to have. You know perfectly well I wasn't made to be mixed up in all this with the rest of you.

We are vulgar folk, sir. *He* is the fine gentleman. I fix him now and again with a look that makes him lower his eyes — because he knows what he did to me.

I?

You — *you*! I owe my life on the streets to you. Did you, or did you not, deny us — I won't say the warmth of home, but even the bare hospitality that makes a guest feel at ease? We were intruders, come to disturb the kingdom of your *legitimacy*. It was *his* behaviour that made me insist on the reason I had come — with my mother, who is his mother too. *And I came as mistress of the house.*

It's easy for them to put me always in the wrong. One day, gentlemen, a young woman of impudent bearing arrives at my home, asking for my father. Then she returns, bolder, with that child there — and asks him for money, in a way that lets one suppose he *must* give it. Must. Because he has every obligation.

But I have, in fact, this obligation. I owe it to your mother.

How should I know? When had I ever seen or heard of her? One day there arrive with her that lad and this baby here. I am told: "This is your mother. Also." I divine from her manner why they have come home. I had rather not say what I feel about it. I shouldn't even care to confess it to myself. No action can therefore be hoped for from me in this affair. Believe me, sir — I am an "unrealised" character. Leave me out of it, I beg you.

What? It is just because you are so that...

How do you know what I am like? When did you ever *bother your head* about me? You all need me because somebody must be guilty who did nothing.

I admit it. I admit it. But isn't that a situation in itself? This aloofness of yours, so cruel to me and to your mother, who comes home and sees you almost for the first time as a grown man, who doesn't recognise you but knows you are her son... See, she's crying!

Like a fool.

She can't stand him, you know. He says he doesn't come into the affair, whereas he is really the hinge of the whole action. Look at that lad who is always clinging to his mother, frightened and humiliated. It is on account of this fellow here. He feels himself more a stranger than the others — mortified at being brought into a home out of charity, as it were. The image of his father. Hardly talks at all.

Oh, we'll cut him out. You've no notion what a nuisance boys are on the stage...

The little girl vanishes first. Then the boy. Then she runs. And what remains? Three people in the same house, unable to belong to one another. A family, perhaps — but without faith, without warmth, without any place where happiness could take root.

Damn it... there is something in what you say. I don't like it, but it interests me.

When you've got a character like me.

You be quiet!

It's new... hem... yes... You've got a nerve, though — to come here and fling it at me like this.

You will understand, sir, born as we are for the stage...

Are you amateur actors then? Because we, sir, are a professional company, with a season to fill.

No, sir. We do not act like amateurs. We live the roles life has cast us in.

Well, well, that will do. But you see, without an author... I could give you the address of an author if you like...

No, no. Look here! You must be the author. You need not invent us — only give us form.

I? What are you talking about?

Yes, you, you! Why not?

Because I have never been an author: that's why.

Then become one now — not by inventing, sir, but by listening. We are already here. You need only take us down.

It won't do.

What? When you see us live our drama...

Yes, that's all right. But you want someone to write it.

No, no. Someone to take it down, possibly, while we play it, scene by scene! It will be enough to sketch it out at first, and then try it over.

Well... It's a bit of an idea. One might have a shot at it.

Of course. You'll see what scenes will come out of it. I can give you one, at once...

God help me, it tempts me. I ought to throw you out — and instead I want to see the first scene. Come to my office. We'll see what can be done. Who knows — we may get something extraordinary out of it.

Extraordinary, yes — if he does not get to tell it alone.

They had better come with us too, hadn't they?

Yes, yes. Come on! come on! Be punctual, please!

Is he serious? He has taken six strangers into his office and left us standing here like furniture.

They are not ordinary strangers.

No. Ordinary strangers do not arrive with a tragedy already rehearsed.

And now he wants us to make a play out of them. In twenty minutes.

Perhaps there is a play.

There is always a play. The question is whether anyone is being paid to be in it.

I only let them in.

That is not a defence.

They looked expected.

Am I taking this down?

Take everything down, Arsenii. It may be evidence.

Nonsense! nonsense! Do it yourselves! I'm not going to mix myself up in this mess. Come on, Rosetta, let's run!

My little darling! You're frightened, aren't you? You don't know where we are. Don't be afraid, Rosetta. It's only a stage — a place where they make false things and call them true. A fountain — just suppose it, here, in the middle. All make-believe, my pet; and better so, for a real one would only frighten you. You who are real, baby dear — who really played by a real fountain, green and beautiful, with the little ducks. And you — what have you got there? Ah. Where did you get this? Idiot. If I had been in your place — instead of killing myself, I'd have shot one of those two. Or both. Father and son.

Come on, come on dear! Come here for a minute! We've arranged everything. It's all fixed up.

If you please, young lady, there are one or two points to settle still. Will you come along?

Ouff! what's the good, if you've arranged everything.

Oh this is fine. Fine. And to think I can't even get away.

Isn't my punishment the worst of all? My God. Why are you so cruel? Isn't it enough for one person to carry all this? Must you make others see it too?

My son —

And they want to put it on the stage. If there was at least a reason for it. He thinks he has got at the meaning of it all. Just as if each one of us, in every circumstance of life, couldn't find his own explanation of it. He complains he was discovered in a place where he ought not to have been seen, in a moment of his life that should have stayed hidden. And what about *my* case? Haven't I had to reveal

what no son ought ever to reveal — how father and mother live, and are man and wife, for themselves — quite apart from that idea of father and mother which we give them?

Mon Dieu. I've stopped writing it down. I don't want a record of this one.

Come on, come on, ladies and gentlemen! Right — you there, machinist!

Yes, sir.

Fix up the white parlor with the floral decorations. Two wings and a drop with a door will do. Hurry up!

Just have a look, and see if there isn't a sofa or divan in the wardrobe...

There's the green one. It is the sofa we have.

No no! Green won't do. It was yellow, ornamented with flowers — very large! and most comfortable!

It doesn't matter. Use the one we've got.

Doesn't matter? It's most important!

We're only trying it now. Please don't interfere. See if we've got a shop window — long and narrowish.

And the little table! The little mahogany table for the pale blue envelope!

There's that little gilt one.

That'll do fine.

And the screen! There must be a screen. Otherwise how am I to *manage*?

That's all right, Miss. We've got any amount of them.

We want some clothes pegs too, don't we?

Yes. Several. There were always several. On the wall by the screen.

See how many we've got and bring them all.

Right.

Take your seat. Look here: this is the outline of the scenes, act by act. And now I'm going to ask you to do something out of the ordinary.

Take it down in shorthand? Sir — *in shorthand*?

Exactly! Can you do shorthand?

Yes, a little.

Good! Go and get some paper from my office, plenty, as much as you can find. You follow the scenes as we play them, and try and get the points down, at any rate the most important ones. Clear the stage, ladies and gentlemen! Come over here and listen attentively.

But, excuse me, we...

Don't worry! You won't have to improvise.

What do we do, then — sit and watch?

Nothing. For the moment you just watch and listen. Everybody will get his part written out afterwards. At present we're going to try the thing as best we can. They're going to act now.

We? What do you mean, if you please, by a rehearsal?

A rehearsal for them.

But since we are the characters...

All right: "characters" then, if you insist on calling yourselves such. But here, my dear sir, the characters don't act. Here the actors do the acting. The characters are there, in the "book" — when there is a "book"!

I won't contradict you; but excuse me, the actors aren't the characters. They want to be, they pretend to be, don't they? Now if these gentlemen here are fortunate enough to have us alive before them...

Oh this is grand! You want to come before the public yourselves then?

As we are...

I can assure you it would be a magnificent spectacle!

What is the use of us here, then?

You're not seriously going to pretend you can act? It makes me laugh! There, you see, they are laughing at the notion. But, by the way, I must cast the parts. That won't be difficult. They cast themselves. You play the Mother. We must find her a name.

Amalia, sir.

But that is the real name of your wife. We don't want to call her by her real name.

Why not, if it's her name?... Still, perhaps, if that lady must... I see this woman here as Amalia. But do as you like. I don't know what to say to you. Already I can hear my own words ring false...

Don't you worry about it. It'll be our job to find the right tones. And as for her name, if you want her to be Amalia, Amalia she is. If you don't like it, we'll find another! For the moment though, we'll call the characters in this way: You are the Son. You naturally are the Step-Daughter...

What? *What?* I — that woman there?

What is there to laugh at?

Nobody has ever dared to laugh at me. Nobody. I insist on being treated with respect — otherwise I go.

No, no, excuse me... I'm not laughing at you...

You should feel honored to be played by...

"That woman there"...

But I wasn't speaking of *you*, you know. I was speaking of myself — whom I can't see in you at all. I don't know quite how to put it — but no, you really aren't anything like me.

True. Here's the point. Look here, sir, our temperaments, our souls...

Temperament, soul — to hell with all that! Your soul, or whatever you like to call it, takes shape *here*: my actors give it body, voice, gesture. They have given voice to material far loftier than this little drama of yours — and if it holds the stage at all, the merit will be theirs.

I don't dare contradict you, sir; but, believe me, it is a terrible suffering for us who are as we are, with these bodies of ours, these features to see...

Good heavens! The make-up will remedy all that, man, the make-up... On the stage, you as yourself cannot exist. The actor here acts you, and that's an end to it!

I understand. And now I think I see why our author who conceived us as we are, all alive, didn't want to put us on the stage after all. I haven't the least desire to offend your actors. Far from it! But when I think that I am to be acted by... I don't know by whom...

By me, if you've no objection.

Honored, I assure you, sir. Still, I must say that try as this gentleman may, with all his good will and wonderful art, to absorb me into himself...

Oh — come off it. "Wonderful art." Withdraw that, please.

It will be difficult to act me as I am. What you will see is how he imagines me — if he imagines me at all — never how I feel myself to be, in here. Whoever judges us ought to remember that.

Heavens! The man's starting to think about the critics now! Let them say what they like. It's up to us to put on the play if we can. Come on! come on! Is the stage set? Stand back — stand back! Let me see, and don't let's lose any more time! Is it all right as it is now?

Well, to tell the truth, I don't recognize the scene.

My dear lady, you can't possibly suppose that we can construct that shop of Madame Pace piece by piece here? You said a white room with flowered wall paper, didn't you?

Yes.

Well then. We've got the furniture right more or less. Bring that little table a bit further forward. You go and find an envelope, if possible, a pale blue one; and give it to that gentleman.

An ordinary envelope?

Yes, yes, an ordinary envelope.

At once, sir.

Ready, everyone! First scene — the Young Lady. No, no, you must wait. I meant her You just watch —
How I'll play it, how I'll live it!...

I'll live it too, you may be sure, as soon as I begin!

Ladies and gentlemen, if you please! No more useless discussions! Scene I: the young lady with
Madame Pace: Oh! And this Madame Pace, where is she?

She isn't with us, sir.

Then what the devil's to be done? I cannot rehearse a character who has not arrived.

But she is alive too.

Yes, but where is she?

One minute. Let me speak! If these ladies would be so good as to give me their hats for a moment...

Our hats?

What are you going to do with the ladies' hats?

Oh nothing. I just want to put them on these pegs for a moment. And one of the ladies will be so kind as
to take off her mantle...

Why our hats?

Are we still rehearsing?

To hang them up here for a moment. Please be so kind, will you?

Exactly; just like that, on show.

May we know why?

I'll tell you. Who knows if, by arranging the stage for her, she doesn't come here herself, attracted by the
very articles of her trade? Look! Look!

There she is! There she is!

It's she! I said so, didn't I? There she is!

What sort of a trick is this?

What's going to happen next? Have we lost the script entirely?

Where did *she* come from? She wasn't here a moment ago. She wasn't anywhere.

It's some trick. Someone arranged this. ...Didn't they?

Excuse me — all of you. Why so eager to destroy, in the name of your ordinary little truth, a thing the stage itself has just conjured into being? Which of your actresses was to play Madame Pace? Here she is — Madame Pace herself. Any actress you cast would be less true than the woman standing there. That is all.

Well? well?

What does she say? Madame — speak up.

Louder! Louder please!

Louder? *Louder*? What on earth are you talking about? These aren't matters one shouts at the top of one's voice. If I spoke them loud, sir, it was to *shame* him and have my revenge. But for Madame it's quite a different matter.

Indeed? indeed? But here, you know, people have got to make themselves heard, my dear. Even we who are on the stage can't hear you — what will it be when the public's in the theatre? You've got to pretend to be alone in a room at the back of a shop where no one can hear you — and still make the whole house hear.

What do you mean by no?

There's someone who will hear us if she speaks out loud.

What? Have you got someone else to spring on us now?

No, no sir. She is alluding to me. I've got to be here — there behind that door, in waiting; and Madame Pace knows it. In fact, if you will allow me, I'll go there at once, so I can be quite ready.

No! Wait! wait! We must observe the conventions of the theatre. Before you are ready...

No, get on with it at once! I'm just dying, I tell you, to act this scene. If he's ready, I'm more than ready.

But, my dear young lady, first of all, we must have the scene between you and this lady... Do you understand?...

Good Heavens! She's been telling me what you know already: that my mother's work is badly done again, that the material's ruined; and that if I want her to continue to help us in our misery I must be patient...

Good afternoon, good afternoon, sir! Here I am, here I am — so sorry I am late, so sorry — the traffic, the trams in this town, always the same. Madame Pace, sir — dresses and coats, off the rue de Bourg, the courtyard near Saint-François. You know me. All Lausanne, it know me. Forty years. Forty years in this canton, sir, and never one bad word about Pace. I no wanta be hard, eh? I no wanta take advantage. I am a good woman, sir. Only — the lady over there, she ruin the silk. Again. The third time this month, sir — the third time. Silk, sir, you no pay with the tears. Somebody must pay. The mother, she pay with the hands — or the little one, she pay. Either way, sir — the book, she balance. Pace, she always balance the book.

What? What? She talks like that?

Yes yes, that's the way she talks — that accent of hers! Most comical it is!

It seem not very polite, gentlemen, to laugh at me — when I try to speak proper for the customers. My customers — eh — they no laugh, sir. They come back. Wednesday afternoon. Friday afternoon. Sometimes the Sunday, after the church. Like the bells of Saint-François. You hear those bells, sir, in this town? Three time a week. *Bom. Bom. Bom.*

Perfect! Of course! Of course! Let her talk like that! Just what we want. Talk just like that, Madame, if you please! The effect's guaranteed — exactly what we needed, a bit of comic relief to lift all this gloom. Of course she talks like that! Magnificent!

Magnificent? Certainly! When such things are said to a girl in language of that kind, the effect is certain, since it seems almost a joke. One feels inclined to laugh when one hears her recite her inventory of clients — clean ones, polite ones, paying ones — as if she were counting bolts of silk. Nice old gentleman, eh, Madame?

Not so old, my dear. Not so old. Forty-five, maybe fifty — the age when a man have money in the pocket and shame in the throat, eh, sir? The best age, my dear, in my long experience. He clean. He polite. He pay cash. The blue envelope on the little mahogany table, you no even gotta look at his face, you no even gotta count. The polite ones, sir — they count for you. He no ask your name. He no need to. He call you little one, he call you dear, he call you whatever please him — for that little while the name belong to him. And if you no like him? Eh — no scandal. Nobody talk. It stay quiet, like everything in this town. Like the silk. Like the sewing. Like everything that get ruin in Pace's shop. The lady know. The lady stay quiet too.

You old devil! You murderess! Three years you took her from me. Three years. I sat at your kitchen table with the needle in my hand, and the tea you served me — your kind tea, your terrible kind tea — and somewhere I knew. Somewhere, in the back of my head, I half-knew. But if I let myself know it, the children at home did not eat. So I drank the tea. I drank your tea, madame, every Wednesday, every Friday, sometimes the Sunday — and I did not let myself see that my own daughter was just down the corridor in your back room. May God forgive me. May God forgive me. I drank the tea.

Calm yourself, Mother, calm yourself! Please don't...

And the smile, devil. The smile you had for me when I came into the kitchen with the finished sewing. I thought it was a kindness. I thought you were the only person in Lausanne with a kindness in her for a poor widow from another town. May God forgive me — I thought it was a kindness.

Calm yourself! Don't get excited! Sit down now!

Well then. Take that woman out of my sight.

It is impossible for my mother to remain here.

They can't be here together — that's why that woman wasn't with us when we came. If they are on together, the whole thing is given away. Inevitably. As you see.

It doesn't matter. This is only a first rough sketch — just to get an idea of the various points of the scene, even confusedly... Come along, my dear lady, sit down now, and let's get on with the scene...

Come on, Madame, come on!

Eh no, thank you. The mother present — it is not possible, sir. It is against the rule. I have my method. I have had my method for forty years. The mother she stay in the kitchen with the tea, like always. The little one she come down the corridor when Pace she ring the little bell. The business it no close while the mother she watch. The chickens too, sir. Even the chickens — you no kill them where the hen can see. The hen, she scream. The hen, she ruin the meat. It is a rule of the house. House rule. Pace, she keep the house rules.

Nonsense! Bring on this *old gentleman* who wants to talk so nicely to me. We've got to do this scene one way or another, haven't we? Come on! You can go!

Yes yes, of course. I go. I go. But my dear — you remember. Without Pace, nothing. You still in the school with your braids and your stomach empty, your little sister at home crying for the bread that is not in the house. You owe it all to me. To Pace. And when the lady ruin the next silk — and she will, my dear, she always do — you know where to find me. There is always the next silk, my dear. There is always the debt. There is always Pace. Don't you forget the name.

Now you make your entry. No, you needn't go over there. Come here. Let's suppose you've already come in. Like that, yes! I'm here with my head bowed, modest-like. Come on! Out with your voice! Say "Good afternoon, Miss" in that peculiar tone, that special tone...

Excuse me, but are you the Manager, or am I? Get on with it, man! Go down there to the back of the stage. You needn't go off. Then come right forward here.

Ready! ready? Get ready to write now.

Good afternoon, Miss.

Good afternoon!

Ah... but... ah... I say... this isn't the first time you've come here, is it?

No sir.

You've been here before, eh? More than once? Well then, there's no need to be so shy, is there? May I take off your hat?

No sir... I'll do it myself.

Oh, my God. My God.

Give it to me! I'll put it down. But a dear little head like yours should have a smarter hat. Come and help me choose one from the stock, won't you?

I say... those are *our* hats, you know.

Silence! silence! Don't try and be funny, if you please... We're playing the scene now I'd have you notice. Begin again, please!

No thank you, sir.

Oh, come now. Don't talk like that. You must take it. I'll be upset if you don't. There are some lovely little hats here; and then — Madame will be pleased. She expects it, anyway, you know.

No, no! I couldn't wear it!

Oh, you're thinking about what they'd say at home if they saw you come in with a new hat? My dear girl, there's always a way round these little matters, you know.

No, it's not that. I couldn't wear it because I am — as you see — you might have noticed.

... in mourning. Of course. I beg your pardon. I'm — I'm frightfully sorry...

Stop! Stop! It's I who must thank you. There's no need for you to feel mortified or specially sorry. Don't think any more of what I've said. I must forget that I am dressed so...

Stop a minute! Stop! Don't write that down. Cut out that last bit. Fine! it's going fine! And now you can go on as we arranged. Pretty good that scene, where he offers her the hat, eh?

The best's coming now. Why can't we go on?

Have a little patience! Of course, it must be treated rather lightly.

Still — with a bit of go in it. Which I, of course, will provide.

Of course. It's easy enough. Shall you and I try it now?

Why, yes! I'll prepare my entrance.

See here! The scene between you and Madame Pace is finished. I'll have it written out properly after. You remain here... oh, where are you going?

One minute. I want to put my hat on again.

Good! You stay here with your head bowed down a bit.

But she isn't dressed in black.

But I shall be. And much more effectively than you.

Be quiet please, and watch! You'll be able to learn something. Come on! come on! Entrance, please!

Good afternoon, Miss...

No! no!

Silence! And you please just stop that laughing. If we go on like this, we'll never finish.

Forgive me, sir, but it's natural enough. This lady stands there still; but if she is supposed to be me, I can assure you that if I heard anyone say "Good afternoon" in that manner and in that tone, I would burst out laughing — exactly as I did.

Yes, yes, the manner, the tone...

Nonsense! Rubbish! Stand aside and let me see the action.

If I've got to play an old man walking into a place of — shall we say — *equivocal character*, and we all know what we mean, then at the very least let me find the door.

Don't listen to them, for Heaven's sake! Do it again! It goes fine. Well?

Good afternoon, Miss.

Good afternoon.

Ah, but... I say... this is not the first time that you have come here, is it?

Good — but not so heavily. And you say: "No, sir."

No, sir.

You've been here before, more than once.

No, no, stop! Let her nod "yes" first. "You've been here before, eh?"

Oh my God!

What's the matter?

Nothing, nothing!

Go on!

You've been here before, eh? Well then, there's no need to be so shy, is there? May I take off your hat?

Don't stop. Don't stop. We're past the worst of it. Carry on!

No sir... I'll do it myself.

Allow me — I'll put it down for you. But a dear little head like yours should have a smarter hat. Come and help me choose one from the stock, won't you?

No thank you, sir.

Oh come now — you must take it. I'll be upset if you don't. There's always a way round these little matters, you know.

It's not the hat, sir. I couldn't wear it because I am — as you see — you might have noticed.

...in mourning. Of course. I beg your pardon. I'm frightfully sorry.

It's I who must thank you. There's no need for you to feel mortified or specially sorry. Don't think any more of what I've said. I must forget that I am dressed so...

Good. Good. Get that down. We'll skip the back-and-forth on the mourning — straight through to the next beat.

He didn't say "I'm frightfully sorry."

We've done that bit. Move on.

He said "Oh." And then he didn't move. His hand stayed on the hat.

Yes. He said "Oh."

Sir, I cannot work with the originals standing five feet away correcting every breath. Either they sit or I sit.

They will sit down.

We will not.

I am not going to stand here being made a fool of by that woman. I have been made a fool of — believe me — by considerably better.

Neither am I. I am through with this scene.

Silence! for once and all, I tell you!

Forgive me! forgive me!

You haven't any manners: that's what it is! You go too far.

Yes, it's true, but excuse her...

Excuse what? It's absolutely disgusting.

Yes, sir, but believe me, it has such a strange effect when...

Strange? Why strange? Where is it strange?

No, sir; I admire your actors — this gentleman here, this lady; but they are certainly not us!

I should hope not. Evidently they cannot be you, if they are actors.

Just so — actors. They act our parts exceedingly well. But what comes out is theirs now, and no longer ours — and we must stand here and watch it happen.

But naturally, inevitably. I've told you so already.

Yes, I understand... I understand...

Well then, let's have no more of it! We'll have the rehearsals by ourselves, afterwards, in the ordinary way. I never could stand rehearsing with the author present. He's never satisfied! Come on! Let's get on with it again; and try and see if you can't keep from laughing.

Oh, I shan't laugh any more. There's a nice little bit coming for me now: you'll see.

Well then: when she says "Don't think any more of what I've said. I must forget, etc.," you come in sharp with "I understand, I understand"; and then you ask her why she is in mourning.

Not at all! See here, sir — when I told him it was useless for me to think about wearing mourning, do you know what he said? "Ah well," he said, "then let's take this little dress off."

Great! Just what we want, to make a riot in the theatre!

But it's the truth!

What does that matter? Acting is our business here. Truth up to a certain point, but no further.

No, sir. What you want is a little *romantic sentimental* scene pieced together out of my disgust — out of every cruel and vile reason I am what I am. He is to ask me why I wear mourning; I am to answer, with tears in my eyes, that it is just two months since papa died. No, sir. No. He has to say to me — as he did say, the way one speaks to a child — *well, let's take this little dress off*.

For Heaven's sake! What are you saying?

The truth. The truth.

It may be. I don't deny it, and I can understand all your horror; but you must surely see that you can't have this kind of thing on the stage. It won't go.

Not possible, eh? Very well — I'm much obliged to you. But I won't stay here. I will not. I can see you've fixed it all up with him in your office. All this talk about what is *possible* on the stage — I understand. He wants his complicated head-drama. His guilt. His torments. All performed in good taste. But I want to act my part. *My part*.

Ah! Just your part! But there are other parts than yours — his and hers. On the stage you can't have one character overshadowing all the others. The thing is to pack them into a neat little framework and act what isactable. From your point of view, every character would tell the public all his troubles in a nice monologue. You must restrain yourself, my dear — this fury of yours may make a bad impression.

It's true. But remember those others mean *him* for me all the same.

What? The others? What do you mean?

For a woman who has gone wrong, sir, the man responsible for the first fault is responsible for everything that follows. He is responsible for *all* my faults — was responsible, before I was even born. Look at him, sir. See if it isn't true.

Well, well! And does the weight of so much responsibility seem nothing to you? Give him a chance to act it, to get it over!

How? How can he act his *noble guilt*, his *moral suffering*, if you want to spare him the horror of being discovered one day — after he had asked her what he asked her — in the arms of her, that already fallen woman, that *child*, sir — the child he used to watch come out of school?

At present, we are unknown to the public. Tomorrow, you will act us as you wish, treating us in your own manner. But do you really want to see drama, do you want to see it flash out as it really did?

Of course! That's just what I do want, so I can use as much of it as is possible.

Well then, ask that Mother there to leave us.

No! No! Don't permit it, sir, don't permit it!

But it's only to try it.

I can't bear it. I can't.

But since it has happened already... I don't understand!

It's taking place now. It happens all the time. My torment isn't a pretended one. I live and feel every minute of my torture. Those two children there — have you heard them speak? They can't speak any more. They cling to me to keep my torment actual and vivid. But for themselves, they do not exist. They aren't any more. And she has run away, she has left me, and is lost.

The eternal moment. She is here to catch me, fix me, and pin me forever to that one shameful moment of my life. She can't give it up. And you, sir, cannot fairly spare me it either.

I never said I didn't want to act it. It will form, in fact, the nucleus of the whole first act right up to her surprise.

Just so! This is my punishment: the passion in all of us that must culminate in her final cry.

I can hear it still in my ears. It has driven me mad, that cry. You may put me on as you like — fully dressed, if you like — provided I have at least my arm bare. Because, standing like this, with my head so and my arms round his neck, I saw a vein pulsing in my arm here; and then, as if that live vein had awakened disgust in me, I closed my eyes like this, and let my head sink against his breast. Cry out, mother. *Cry out as you did then!*

No! My daughter, my daughter! You brute! you brute! She is my daughter! Don't you see she's my daughter?

Fine. Fine. Damned good. And then, of course — curtain.

Yes, of course, because that's the way it really happened.

Oh, yes, no doubt about it. Curtain here, curtain!

The darned idiot! I said "curtain" to show the act should end there, and he goes and lets it down in earnest. Yes, yes, it's all right. Effect certain! That's the right ending. I'll guarantee the first act at any rate.

Ah yes: the second act! Leave it to me, leave it all to me as we arranged, and you'll see! It'll go fine!

Our entry into his house in spite of him...

Leave it to me, I tell you!

Do let it be clear, at any rate, that it is in spite of my wishes.

For all the good that's come of it...

It doesn't matter. The more harm done us, the more remorse for him.

I understand! Good Heavens! I understand! I'm taking it into account.

I beg you, sir, to let it appear quite plain that for conscience' sake I did try in every way...

... to pacify me, to dissuade me from spiting him. Do as she wants: satisfy her, because it's true! I enjoy it immensely. Any how, as you can see, the meeker she is, the more she tries to get at his heart, the more distant and aloof does he become.

Are we going to begin this second act or not?

I'm not going to talk any more now. But I must tell you this: you can't have the whole action take place at the fountain, as you suggest. It isn't possible!

Why not?

Because he is always shut up alone in his room. And then there's all the part of that poor dazed-looking boy there which takes place indoors.

Maybe! On the other hand, you will understand — we can't change scenes three or four times in one act.

They used to change scenes like that once.

Yes, when the public was up to the level of that child there.

It makes the illusion easier. The audience needs to know which room we are in. They aren't going to *guess*.

The *illusion*. For Heaven's sake — don't say *illusion*. Please. Don't use that word. It is particularly painful for us.

And why, if you please?

It is painful. Cruel. Really cruel. And you should understand that.

But why? What ought we to say then? The illusion, I tell you, sir, which we've got to create for the audience...

With our acting.

The illusion of a reality.

I understand. You, perhaps, do not understand us. Forgive me. For you and your actors, the thing is only — and rightly so — a kind of game...

A *game*? We are serious actors, sir. We have training.

I don't deny it. What I mean is the game, or play, of your art, which has to give, as the gentleman says, a perfect illusion of reality.

Precisely —!

Now, if you consider the fact that we, as we are, have no other reality outside of this illusion...

And what does that mean?

As I say, sir, that which is a game of art for you is our sole reality. But not only for us, you know, by the way. Just think it over. Can you tell me who you are?

What? Who am I? I am myself.

And if I were to tell you that that isn't true. Because *you* and *I*...

I should say you were mad —!

You're quite right to laugh. We are all making believe here. So you can object that it's only a joke for that gentleman there to play me — who am, on the contrary, myself: this thing you see. You see — I've caught you in a *trap*.

But we've had all this over once before. Do you want to begin again?

No, no. That wasn't my meaning. In fact — I'd like to ask you to abandon this game of art which you are accustomed to play here with your actors. And to ask you, seriously, once again. *Who are you?*

If this fellow here hasn't got a nerve! A man who calls himself a character comes and asks me who I am!

A character, sir, may always ask a man who he is. Because a character really does have a life of his own, marked with his own particular features. Which is why he is always *somebody*. But a man — I'm not speaking of you now — may very well be *nobody*.

Yes, but you are asking these questions of me, the boss, the manager! Do you understand?

Only this: the man you are today once believed himself someone else entirely — someone who now means nothing to you, who barely seems to have existed. Don't you feel the ground go soft under you, knowing this *you* of today will look like an illusion to you tomorrow?

Is this still the play, or has it become something else?

His *reality*. He always knew exactly where to find me.

Well. Well. And where does all this take us anyway?

Nowhere — only to this: we have nothing but the illusion you call our reality. And you, sir, have no more than that. You only think you do.

Ah, excellent! Then you'll be saying next that you, with this comedy of yours that you brought here to act, are truer and more real than I am.

But of course. Without doubt.

He was real that afternoon. With his hundred francs. He was very real.

Ah, really?

Why, I thought you'd understand that from the beginning.

More real than I?

If your reality can change from one day to another...

But everyone knows it can change. It is always changing, the same as anyone else's.

His doesn't change. Mine doesn't either. He should know.

No, sir. Not ours. That is the difference. Our reality cannot change — it is fixed, forever; it cannot be other than what it is. And that is what should make you shudder as you come near us: yours shifts with the day, and ours is nailed shut. We are the thing we did. And we will do it again tonight. And tomorrow. And every night you choose to put us on.

Oh for God's sake, will you at least finish with this philosophising, and let's try and shape this comedy you yourself have brought me? You argue and philosophise a bit too much, my dear sir. You know you seem to me almost, almost... Ah, by the way, I think you introduced yourself to me as a — what shall we call it — a "character," created by an author who did not afterward care to make a drama of his own creations.

It is the simple truth, sir.

Nonsense! Cut that out, please! None of us believes it — it isn't a thing one can believe seriously. It seems to me you are imitating the manner of a certain author whom I heartily detest — I warn you — though I have unfortunately bound myself to put on one of his works. I was just starting to rehearse it when you arrived. And this is what we've gained — out of the frying-pan into the fire!

I don't know your detested author, sir. I only know this: a man never thinks so hard as when he suffers — he must learn who did it to him, and whether he deserved it. Let me suffer in silence, like an animal, and you call it human. Let me ask *why*, and suddenly it is forbidden.

I would like to go home. Quietly. Now.

Sir — plainer. Shorter. We have actors here who'd like to know what they're being asked to play. Tonight, if possible.

I am not philosophising, sir. I am explaining.

Look here. Look here. You're off again — philosophising worse than ever.

Because I am in pain, sir — and a man in pain reasons; he cannot help it. Pain is the one thing your stage can rehearse and never feel.

I'd like to know if anyone has ever heard of a character who climbs right out of his part and makes speeches the way you do. Have you ever heard of such a thing? I haven't.

Because authors hide the labour, sir. When a character is truly alive, the author only follows him — and the character takes on a life so far his own that he can be imagined in scenes the author never dreamed of.

Listen to him. Even now he is the author.

Yes, yes, I know this.

So what is there to wonder at in us? To be born of an author's fantasy, and be denied life by him — weren't these characters, left alive and yet without life, right to do what they are doing now, after trying everything to persuade him? We've all tried him in turn — I, she and she.

Should we — should someone — stop this? I keep waiting for one of you to say that we should.

I tempted him too — many times. He would sit at his writing-table at twilight, too tired to turn on the lamp, and the shadows would fill with us, come to tempt him. Let us live, I would whisper — the mother with her son, I with the little ones, and then I alone in the dark, offering him scene after scene. Ah! my life! my life! And he turned away from all of it.

Maybe. But perhaps it was your fault that he refused to give us life: because you were too insistent, too troublesome.

Nonsense! Didn't he make me so himself? In my opinion he abandoned us in a fit of depression, of disgust for the ordinary theatre as the public knows it and likes it.

Exactly what it was, sir. *Exactly* that.

Not at all! Don't believe it for a minute. Listen to me! You'll be doing quite right to modify, as you suggest, the excesses both of this girl here, who wants to do too much, and of this young man, who won't do anything at all.

No, nothing!

You too overstep the mark occasionally, my dear sir, if I may say so.

I? When? Where? Give me one instance.

Always! Continuously! Then there's this insistence of yours in trying to make us believe you are a character. And then too, you must really argue and philosophize less, you know, much less.

Take away my torment, sir — the torment that never gives me peace — and you suppress me. That's all. A man does not merely live; he gives his own life a meaning. I will not be reduced to a mere fact, as she wants. It would destroy my reason for being.

Your *raison d'être*! Oh, we're going ahead fine! First she starts off, and then you jump in. At this rate, we'll never finish.

Now, don't be offended! Have it your own way — provided, however, that within the limits of the parts you assign us each one's sacrifice isn't too great.

You've got to understand that you can't go on arguing at your own pleasure. Drama is action, sir, action and not damned philosophy.

All right. I'll do just as much arguing and philosophizing as everybody does when he is considering his own torments.

If the drama permits — which at this rate, sir, I doubt it will. For Heaven's sake, man, let's get along and come to the scene.

It seems to me we've got too much action with our coming into his house. You said, before, you couldn't change the scene every five minutes.

Of course not. What we've got to do is combine and group all the facts into one simultaneous, close-knit action. We can't have it as you want, with your little brother wandering like a ghost from room to room, hiding behind doors and meditating a project which — what did you say it did to him?

Consumes him, sir. Wastes him away. He has not eaten properly since we came into that house.

Well, it may be. And then at the same time, you want the little girl there to be playing by the fountain... one in the house, and the other out at the fountain: isn't that it?

Yes, in the sun, in the sun! That is my only pleasure — to see her happy and careless by the fountain, after the misery and squalor of the horrible room where we all four slept together. And I had to sleep beside her — I, do you understand? — carrying everything I carried, next to her, with her folding me in her loving little arms. By the fountain, whenever she spied me, she would run to take me by the hand. She loved the little flowers, and would show them to me.

Well then, we'll have it at the fountain. Everything shall happen at the fountain — we'll group the other scenes there. The fountain basin — set it there. Good — you've fixed it up. The Boy, instead of hiding behind the doors, will wander here by the fountain, hiding behind the basin. It's going to be rather difficult to find a child to do the scene with you where she shows you the flowers. Come forward a little. Let's try it. And this lad — what's the matter with him? We'll have to give him a word or two to say. Hide here — like that. Show your head a little, as if looking for someone.

It's useless to hope he will speak, as long as that fellow there is here... You must send him away first.

Delighted! Delighted! I don't ask for anything better.

No! No! Where are you going? Wait a bit!

I've got nothing to do with this affair. Let me go please! Let me go!

What do you mean by saying you've got nothing to do with this?

Don't bother to stop him. He won't go.

He has to act the terrible scene at the fountain with his mother.

I will act *nothing* at all. I've said so from the very beginning. Let me go.

Allow me? Well, go on then — go away. You see? He *can't*. He is obliged to stay here, *indissolubly bound to the chain*. If I, who fly off when what has to happen happens, because I cannot bear him — if I am still here, enduring that face of his — you can well imagine he is unable to move. He has to remain. With that nice father of his, and that mother whose firstborn he is. Come on, mother, come along! You see? She was getting up to keep him back — she, who dreads showing your actors anything of what she feels. That is how badly she wants to be near him. She is willing to act her part.

No. No. If I can't go away, then I'll stop here. But I repeat. I act nothing.

You can force him, sir.

Nobody can force me.

I can.

Wait a minute, wait... First of all, the baby has to go to the fountain...

Yes, yes of course; that's it. Both at the same time.

What do you mean by both at the same time? It isn't right. There was no scene between me and her. Ask her how it was!

Yes, it's true. I had come into his room...

Into *my* room. Do you understand? Not at the fountain. Nothing about this ever happened out there.

It doesn't matter. Haven't I told you we've got to group the action?

What do you want?

Nothing! I was just looking at you.

Ah! she's at it too — studying her part!

Exactly! And it seems to me that you should be grateful to them for their interest.

Yes — but haven't you yet seen that it isn't possible to live in front of a mirror? One that doesn't simply hold your face, but throws it back at you — twisted into a grimace.

That is true, absolutely true. You must see that.

He's right! Move away from them!

Do as you like. I'm out of this!

Be quiet, you, will you? And let me hear your mother! You were saying you had entered...

Yes. Into his room. I couldn't bear it any more. I went to tell him what I have inside me. All of it. But the moment he saw me...

Nothing happened! There was no scene. I went away, that's all! I don't care for scenes!

It's true, true. That's how it was.

Well now, we've got to do this bit between you and him. It's indispensable.

I'm ready. Whenever you are. If you could just find a moment for me to tell him what I have, here.

You'll do this for your mother, for your mother, do you understand?

I do nothing.

For God's sake, do as I tell you! Don't you hear your mother asking you for a favor? Haven't you even got the guts to be a son?

No! No! And for God's sake stop it, or else...

Please! please!

You've got to obey, do you hear?

What does it mean — this madness you've got? Have you no decency — that you would show the whole world our shame? I won't do it. I won't. The author who made us could not bear to stage this. Neither will I.

Man alive! You came here...

He did! I didn't!

Aren't you here now?

It was his wish, and he dragged us along with him. He's told you not only the things that did happen, but also things that have never happened at all.

Well, tell me then what did happen. You went out of your room without saying a word?

Without a word, so as to avoid a scene!

And then what did you do?

Nothing... walking, out by the fountain...

Well, well... walking, out by the fountain...

Why on earth do you insist? It's horrible!

The baby?

There in the fountain...

She was following him at the moment...

And then you...

I ran over to her. I was jumping in — to drag her out — when I saw something that stopped me where I stood. The boy. Standing stock still. With a look on his face I will never forget. Watching his little sister, there in the water. Then...

My son! My son! Help! Help!

Is he really wounded?

He's dead! dead!

No, no, it's only make believe, it's only pretence!

Pretence? Reality, sir, reality!

Pretence? Reality? To hell with it all.